Animals in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: All Creatures Great and Small: Living Things in the Bible, by Edward R. Hope © 2005 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Domestic animals, cattle, livestock, animal, living being

1.1 Domestic animals, cattle, livestock, animal, living being

References:

Hebrew בְּהֵמָה (behemah) GEN 1:24, GEN 1:25, GEN 1:26, GEN 2:20, GEN 3:14, GEN 6:7, GEN 6:20, GEN 34:23, GEN 36:6, GEN 47:18, EXO 9:9, EXO 9:10, EXO 9:19, EXO 9:22, EXO 9:25

Hebrew בְּעִיר (be'ir) EXO 22:4, EXO 22:4, NUM 20:4, NUM 20:8, NUM 20:11, PSA 78:48

Hebrew מִקְנֶה (miqneh) GEN 4:20, GEN 13:2, GEN 13:7, GEN 26:14, GEN 29:7, GEN 30:29, GEN 31:9, GEN 31:18, GEN 33:17, GEN 34:5, GEN 34:23, GEN 36:6, GEN 36:7, GEN 46:6, GEN 46:32, GEN 46:34, GEN 47:6, GEN 47:16, GEN 47:17, GEN 47:18, EXO 9:3, EXO 9:4, EXO 9:6, EXO 9:7, EXO 9:19, EXO 9:20, EXO 9:21, EXO 10:26, EXO 12:38, EXO 17:3, EXO 34:19, NUM 20:19, NUM 31:9, NUM 32:1, NUM 32:4, NUM 32:16, NUM 32:26, DEU 3:19, JOS 1:14, JOS 14:4, JOS 22:8, JDG 6:5, JDG 18:21, 1SA 23:5, 1SA 30:20, 2KI 3:17, 1CH 5:9, 1CH 5:21, 1CH 7:21, 1CH 28:1, 2CH 14:14, 2CH 26:10, 2CH 32:29, JOB 1:3, JOB 1:10, JOB 36:33, PSA 78:48, ECC 2:7, ISA 30:23, JER 9:9, JER 49:32, EZK 38:12, EZK 38:13

Greek θρέμμα (thremma) JHN 4:12

Latin iumentum 2ES 6:53

Latin pecus 2ES 8:29

Discussion:

These words refer to all kinds of livestock viewed as possessions or "living riches". Although they are translated as "cattle" in some versions they are used in these versions with an archaic more general meaning equivalent to "domestic animals" or "livestock". The meaning includes cattle sheep goats camels and donkeys or in other words any animals kept in large numbers for both domestic and commercial purposes.

Special significance or symbolism:

In the time of the patriarchs Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob livestock were a measure of a man's wealth. A person who owned many livestock was considered "well off." Conversely a person without livestock was a man without status.

Translation:

The best equivalent is an inclusive expression covering all kinds of livestock animals.